Cold War Rivalry, 1969–1988

International politics was turned upside down between 1969 and 1988. In 1969, China and the USSR fought a brief but fierce war. This led to a quasi-alliance between Beijing and Washington. And in 1978, the Saur revolution in Afghanistan overthrew the post-monarchy republican government. A year later, Soviet troops intervened in Afghanistan to restore order in the face of growing instability. The 1970s ended with a deepening of rival alignments that were already a possibility in 1968: India with the USSR, and China with the US. Those alignments persisted to the end of the Cold War, even though by 1982 Delhi and Beijing were edging away from Moscow and Washington, respectively. By the time the USSR unravelled in the late 1980s, India and China had arrived at a détente, underlined by Rajiv Gandhi's trip to China in 1988.

China and the US align

Between March and September 1969, Chinese and Soviet forces fought a series of military battles along their contested border. Responding to the conflict, Moscow tried to rally global communist support against Beijing. Crucially, it also reached out to the US. In the early 1960s, Washington had proposed to Moscow that the two powers combine to stop the Chinese nuclear programme in a joint military strike.[18] In 1969, it was Moscow's turn to explore interest in a combined attack. The Nixon administration, already on its way to normalizing relations with China, made clear it would not be a bystander if the Soviets acted.[19] In the meantime, Washington sent out a series of diplomatic feelers to Beijing. On 31 July 1969, Nixon set off on an international tour, visiting India and then Pakistan, among other countries. The India visit was almost certainly a cover for his main destination, Pakistan, where he had real business. In Islamabad, he asked his host, President Yahya Khan, to intercede with China. On his way home,